

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
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1. PURPOSE

- a. This Departmental manual (DM) establishes procedures for the United States Department of Agriculture's (USDA) enterprise information technology governance (EITG) framework and accompanying governance processes. USDA's EITG framework is called the Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework (IITGF).
- b. This DM provides an overview and implementation guidance for the USDA IITGF. The *Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework: Guidebook* identifies the activities of each of the eight decision gates of the IITGF. Decision gates are aligned with an investment's lifecycle phase and enable USDA to manage its EITG processes.
 - (1) This DM also defines the alignment activities and responsibilities of the Information Technology (IT) Executive Governance Board. These measures facilitate effective IT decision-making within USDA and include touchpoints with other governance, management, and control processes. These include USDA's IT Portfolio Management (ITPM) division, USDA's System Development Lifecycle

approach, project management, enterprise architecture (EA), the risk management framework, IT security and privacy controls, and [Departmental Regulation \(DR\) 3575-004](#), *Information Technology Security Baselines and Security Control Tailoring*. Implementing an Integrated IT Governance Framework further supports the USDA mission by providing organizational alignment for decisions related to technology components, services, and applications.

2. SCOPE

- a. This DM applies to all Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices with USDA major and non-major IT investments.
- b. The USDA IITGF applies to all new and existing USDA major IT investments and projects. This includes enhancements to existing major investments and projects associated with operations, maintenance, and disposition.
- c. The USDA IITGF also applies and should be leveraged during governance for any non-major investments at a Mission Area, agency, or staff office.

3. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS/CANCELLATIONS

- a. This DM provides the procedures for the Departmental policy as outlined in [DR 3130-010](#), *United States Department of Agriculture Enterprise Information Technology Governance*.
- b. This DM is supported by management oversight controls and processes. It consists of:
 - (1) The *Clinger-Cohen Act of 1996* (CCA), [40 United States Code \(U.S.C.\) § 11101, et seq.](#);
 - (2) The *Consolidated and Further Continuing Appropriations Act, 2015*, [Public Law \(P.L.\) 113-235](#); and
 - (3) The *Federal Information Technology Acquisition Reform Act* (FITARA), [P.L. 113-291, Title VIII, Subtitle D, Sections 831-837](#).
- c. This DM is effective immediately when published and will remain in effect until it is superseded or expires. All Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices must align their procedures to comply with this DM within six months of the date of publication.

4. BACKGROUND

- a. There are various legislative and regulatory drivers for implementing ITPM. Many legal reforms emphasize the need for Federal agencies to significantly improve how they plan, select, fund, control, and evaluate IT initiatives. The Federal approach to ITPM has been the select-control-evaluate model championed by OMB in OMB Circular [A-11](#), *Preparation, Submission, and Execution of the Budget*; the Government Accountability Office (GAO); and industry experts since the early 1990s.
- b. To give Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices guidance on implementing CCA and FITARA, OMB offers Circular [A-130](#), *Managing Information as a Strategic Resource*.
- c. The *Consolidated and Further Continuing Appropriations Act, 2015*, P.L. 113-235, Division A, Title VII, Section 706 prohibits the use of funds to acquire new IT systems or significant upgrades without certain approval and concurrences. These include the approval of the Chief Information Officer (CIO) and the concurrence of the Executive IT Investment Review Board (E-Board) and the Committees on Appropriations of both Houses of Congress.

5. PROCEDURES

- a. Definition of IT Governance

IT governance involves collaborating to make strategic decisions about technology within an organization. It connects business and IT leaders, ensuring alignment and adaptability in the ever-evolving IT landscape. It covers four critical areas: strategic alignment, value delivery, risk management, and resource management.

- b. Summary of the IITGF

- (1) The IITGF is a cohesive, streamlined governance structure that provides for executive-level decision-making. It outlines the primary role that each governance board plays within the EITG process. This ensures the accountability and success of governance objectives.
- (2) In the IITGF, governance boards and members represent the full complement of and formal authority over the business, financial, and IT organizations of USDA.
- (3) The IITGF is a comprehensive framework of policies and processes that ensures USDA's formal, responsive, and effective oversight of IT resources. It integrates enterprise and mission area governance, standardizes intake and review workflows, and aligns IT decision-making with USDA's strategic priorities, compliance mandates, and operational needs. This ensures operational efficiency and value delivery in the implementation of IT by enabling timely, evidence-based decisions; reducing duplication and rework through standardized artifacts; and ensuring that

resources are directed toward initiatives with clear institutional fit, measurable impact, and sustained alignment with USDA's mission. The framework spans the entire IT lifecycle from initiation through disposition. The *Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework: Guidebook* defines a series of eight governance decision gates and associated investment lifecycle phases. These promote effective executive oversight and management of IT investments.

- (4) An investment tailoring agreement (ITA) formalizes the requirements for requests to the Integrated Advisory Board (IAB) for customizing or waiving IITGF-specific phases, activities, decision gates, deliverables, or investment governance reviews. These requests are based on specific investment requirements or business needs and can occur in any of the eight decision gates of the IITGF.
 - (a) Personnel can use an ITA to request and obtain authorization. They can also use an ITA to record the rationale for using, omitting, or integrating specific IITGF decision gate reviews. An ITA determines the selection and granularity of deliverables for the investment or project. It indicates the parameters of scope, schedule, budget, and quality, including any exceptions.
 - (b) The Investment Manager or Project Manager (PM) for the investment must initiate and endorse the ITA. After approval by a USDA IT governance board or its delegate, the ITA indicates permission for the project to advance.

c. The Eight Decision Gates of the IITGF

(1) Procedure for the Eight Decision Gates

The procedure for each of the eight decision gates is the same, except for minor differences noted in the description of each decision gate. Each investment or project is required to go through the following steps for each of the eight decision gates to meet IITGF requirements and obtain the necessary reviews and approvals from the required enterprise governance boards.

(a) The Mission Area, Agency, or Staff Office Integrated Project Team (IPT):

- 1 Collaboratively identifies, addresses, and resolves issues (determines requirements);
- 2 Establishes project baselines and contract requirements; and
- 3 Provides required information to the Investment Manager or PM for developing the governance documentation package based on the decision gate.

(b) The Investment Manager or PM:

- 1 Reviews the completed decision gate approval documentation package; and
- 2 Submits the approved documentation package to the Mission Area Agency, or Staff Office Investment Review Board (IRB).

(c) The Mission Area, Agency, or Staff Office IRB:

- 1 Conducts an evaluation of the submitted materials; and
- 2 Decides whether to approve the governance request.
 - a If the governance request is approved, the IRB provides the required updates, action items, and conditions (if applicable) to the Investment Manager or PM.
 - b If the governance request is not approved, the IRB notifies the Investment Manager or PM of the rejection and reason.

(d) The Investment Manager or PM:

- 1 If the governance request was approved, the Investment Manager or PM sends the Decision gate documentation package to the Enterprise Governance Team Liaison prior to the deadline for their IAB.
- 2 If the governance request is not approved, the Investment Manager or PM updates the Decision gate documentation package and resubmits it to the Mission Area, Agency, or Staff Office IRB.

(e) The Enterprise Governance Team Liaison:

- 1 Reviews the decision gate documentation package, supporting documentation, and IRB assessment for completion and accuracy; and
- 2 Notifies the E-Board and IAB of upcoming activities for this decision gate and routes materials and inputs to the E-Board and IAB for review and distribution to IAB and E-Board members in preparation for the meetings.

(f) The E-Board and IAB:

- 1 Review the documentation submitted for the governance request; and
- 2 Decide whether to approve or disapprove it and provide decision memos signed by the appropriate board chair.
 - a If the E-Board and IAB approve the decision gate documentation package, they send a signed approval memo, with any applicable

action items or conditions, to the Mission Area Points of Contact (POC).

- b If the E-Board and IAB do not approve the decision gate documentation package, they send a signed disapproval memo, with applicable action items or conditions to be satisfied before resubmittal, to the Mission Area POCs.

(2) Descriptions of the Decision Gates with Procedure Exceptions

(a) Decision Gate 1: Initiation Review

- 1 Decision gate 1, personnel assess the need for a proposed investment. They evaluate the alignment with Departmental, Mission Area, agency, or staff office strategic planning efforts. This decision gate allows Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices to develop the investment concept with preliminary business requirements, performance measures, benefits, and costs. It allows the integrated IT governance boards to review these proposals and assess the impact and benefit to the overall IT portfolio.
- 2 Each newly proposed IT project or initiative proceeds through IITGF decision gate 1. The IAB decides whether it is a major or non-major investment. [DR 3130-008](#), *Definition of Major Information Technology Investments*, defines major investments. [DR 3130-009](#), *Non-Major Information Technology (IT) Investments*, defines non-major investments.
 - a If the new proposed IT project or initiative is a major IT investment or within a major investment it will follow the governance path in the *Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework: Guidebook*. Review, recommendation, and decision authority at each level will vary based on the criteria and decision type per DR 3130-008.
 - b If it is a non-major investment, the Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO) Information Resource Management Center (IRMC) IT Strategic Planning and Governance (ITSPG) division will inform the Investment Manager or PM that the governance delegation will return to the Mission Area, agency, or staff office. It will then proceed under that Mission Area, agency, or staff office governance structure.

(b) Decision Gate 2: Investment Review

- 1 Decision gate 2 ensures that the proposed or existing investment best supports the Department's mission and objectives. The investments are

prioritized and evaluated for performance as measured by cost, schedule, performance, and risk, as well as technical alignment.

(c) Decision Gate 3: Requirements Review

- 1 Decision gate 3 is required to determine the effectiveness, completion, and accuracy levels achieved throughout the investment's planning activities. This decision gate provides the integrated IT governance boards with information to further understand the strategy by which the proposed investment will achieve its scope, cost, and schedule objectives.

(d) Decision Gate 4: Design Review

- 1 Decision gate 4 is for reviewing an investment's functional requirements. The functional requirements must be complete, unambiguous, and actionable enough to support detailed system design, acquisition planning, and downstream implementation. This decision gate also allows the integrated IT governance boards to gain a complete understanding of the requirements and ensure that the requirements can support a detailed design of the proposed system.

(e) Decision Gate 5: Development and Test Review

- 1 Decision gate 5 ensures that any systems under review can proceed into system fabrication, development, and testing by conducting a formal design review. This review compares the system's final design against the stated performance requirements, cost, schedule, risk, and other constraints. It does so by examining product specifications, engineering drawings, and configuration item documentation to confirm alignment with the product baseline. Independent reviewers and subject matter experts validate that each product in the baseline is fully represented in the detailed design documentation. This structured evaluation, often supported by checklists, compliance matrices, and risk assessments, provides confidence that the system is ready to enter testing.

(f) Decision Gate 6: Implementation Review

- 1 Decision gate 6 is a review of the implementation, ensuring that the development and testing of the investment systems satisfy the desired functional requirements. It accomplishes this by requiring evidence from unit tests, integration tests, and system-level verification reports that demonstrate compliance with business needs, functional requirements, and service level agreements. Reviewers also assess user procedures, training materials, and operational documentation to confirm they meet stakeholder needs. The gate uses test results, defect tracking, and performance metrics to verify that components adhere to physical constraints and operate as

described in the user documentation. This structured review process ensures that the system is not only built correctly but is also usable and supportable in practice.

(g) Decision Gate 7: Operations and Maintenance (O&M)

- 1 Decision gate 7 determines whether system components achieve expected benefits. It provides an evaluation of the investment's development process. It determines whether the investment is ready to go into O&M mode. From the evaluation, there is a recommendation for continuing or modifying an investment.

(h) Decision Gate 8: Disposition Review

- 1 Decision gate 8 determines whether system components are still providing their benefits at a reasonable cost, have reached the end of life, or will be disposed of (retired or decommissioned). After an evaluation, there is a recommendation for terminating or disposing of, an investment.

d. USDA's IT Baseline Management Process

- (1) Earned value management (EVM) is the integrated management system that USDA uses to coordinate the work scope, schedule, and cost goals of a program or contract. USDA also uses it to objectively measure progress toward these goals. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices must implement IT baseline management processes that meet certain minimum requirements that align with EVM best practices and the USDA's enterprise governance process.
- (2) USDA requires compliance for all investments that meet any one of the following criteria:
 - (a) All new IT investments for any Mission Area, agency, or staff office are planning to spend \$20 million or more on development, modernization, and enhancement (DME) over the lifecycle; or
 - (b) All major IT investments currently in process and budgeted for \$20 million or more in DME during the remainder of the lifecycle; or
 - (c) Any investment for which a Mission Area, agency, or staff office is planning to spend \$1 million or more in DME in current-year funding (the Mission Area, agency, or staff office must use EVM to track investment cost, schedule, and performance).

e. Requirements for Integrated Baseline Reviews

- (1) An integrated baseline review is a joint assessment between the USDA Federal PM and the contractor to establish a mutual understanding of the performance measurement baseline (PMB). This understanding provides for an agreement on a plan of action to evaluate the risks inherent in the PMB and the management processes that operate during program execution.
- (2) PMs must conduct integrated baseline reviews on all major investments. They must conduct these within 180 calendar days from project start.
- (3) The Mission Area, agency, or staff office's Investment Manager or PM will submit an integrated baseline review report during the Select phase of the CPIC process. The report will help the Investment Manager or PM understand whether:
 - (a) The scope of the PMB is consistent with authorizing documents;
 - (b) All activities and deliverables required by the statement of work are in the work breakdown structure (WBS);
 - (c) Work packages are at the appropriate level of the WBS;
 - (d) Management control processes are in place; and
 - (e) There are risks in the PMB associated with cost, schedules, and resources, and there are corrective actions where necessary.

f. Requirements for Rebaselines

- (1) A rebaseline is the major realignment of the PMB to improve the correlation between the work plan and the baseline budget, scope, and schedule. Rebaselining does not add or change the existing scope of work. It merely changes how and when personnel may accomplish it within the constraints of the existing contract.
- (2) Personnel must not approve baseline changes for the sole purpose of offsetting variances. Baseline changes are, however, acceptable for unexpected growth within the currently authorized work scope, rate changes, risk handling, and other program unknowns. Rebaselining to offset variances erases important information useful for effective project management. This is counter to the purpose of EVM. However, if measuring and managing the current baseline is no longer viable, and EVM is no longer an effective tool for the management of the project, the project may be rebaselined. The criteria for a rebaseline are as follows:
 - (a) The schedule variance is equal to or greater than 10 percent; or
 - (b) The budget variance is equal to or greater than 10 percent, or equal to or less than minus 10 percent; or

- (c) There is a scope change (any modification, adjustments, or additions to the project's original goals, deliverables, or requirements).

g. Requirements for Portfolio Restructures

- (1) Portfolio restructures are an integral aspect of strategic portfolio management (SPM). They should be part of an ongoing process that focuses on aligning USDA's IT resources with its strategic business goals.
- (2) As USDA continues to adopt agile development methods to respond to the rapidly changing business environment, there is also a need for agility at the strategic level. Portfolio restructurings need to be able to quickly align budgets, resources, projects, and architecture roadmaps to new business strategies.
- (3) A portfolio restructuring enables an organization to neatly organize the information needed to optimize portfolios, improve agility, and set the pace for change. Integrating portfolios enables impact analyses that reduce planning errors and improve synergies between the portfolios.
- (4) SPM needs to be a continuous process. An organization needs to be able to continuously adapt to be resilient. This means continuous analysis, decision-making, IT road mapping, planning, execution, monitoring, and finally returning full circle to analysis. This needs to happen across all organizational hierarchies and units, from strategy to execution. The following items fall under the criteria for a portfolio restructure. Personnel should use the portfolio restructure checklist as appropriate:
 - (a) Addition of new investments;
 - (b) Upgrading investments;
 - (c) Downgrading investments;
 - (d) Eliminating investments;
 - (e) Consolidating investments; and
 - (f) Splitting investments.

h. Requirements for Governance Touchpoints (Annual or Incremental)

- (1) The owners of all USDA major investments must brief the IAB at a minimum annually to ensure alignment with milestones, procurement, and other strategic priorities.

- (2) An annual touchpoint should be completed for steady state or O&M projects that have not been briefed to the IAB in over 1 year.
 - (3) DME projects that have passed Decision gate 2 and are utilizing any agile development methodology should have established reoccurring incremental touchpoints with the IAB that align with the implementation of any major release.
- i. Preparing for Governance Boards and Facilitating Meetings (IAB and E-Board)
- (1) At a minimum, IAB meetings will be scheduled monthly and E-Board meetings scheduled quarterly. The chair of each board can call an ad hoc meeting as necessary. Each investment must go through their Mission Area, agency, or staff office governance board before briefing the IAB and then the E-Board repository. The process should be as follows:
 - (a) The Mission Area, agency, or staff office governance board approves investment and applicable projects.
 - (b) The Mission Area, agency, or staff office capital planning team or Investment Manager coordinates with their ITSPG Liaison to select and confirm the IAB meeting date.
 - (c) The Mission Area, agency, or staff office provides briefing and supporting documentation to the ITSPG Liaison and IT governance mailbox at least 3 weeks before the meeting.
 - (d) Briefing, agendas, and supporting documents are distributed to IAB voting members no later than within 5 business days before the meeting.
 - (e) Voting members have 5 business days to develop questions, comments, feedback, and action items or conditions.
 - (f) The OCIO IRMC ITSPG Governance Team delivers the internal pre-brief to the IAB Chair and Vice Chair 2 days before the meeting.
 - (g) Hold the IAB meeting. The Chair or Vice Chair facilitates the meeting.
 - (h) IAB meeting minutes are finalized and distributed NLT 5 business days after the meeting.
 - (i) Send the final draft of the IAB meeting memo with action items and conditions for the CIO's signature NLT 5 business days after the meeting.
 - (j) Distribute the CIO-signed IAB memo to all stakeholders NLT 1 business day after receipt. Store it in the SharePoint IT governance document repository

along with the briefing, meeting minutes, and other supporting documentation, in accordance with [DR 3080-001](#), *Records Management*.

- (k) Brief each recommended investment to the E-Board. Follow the same steps and timeframes for preparing and briefing the E-Board.
- (2) Attendance will be captured at each meeting:
 - (a) 75 percent of voting member attendance is necessary for a quorum for conducting business and making recommendations regarding actions for items coming before the boards.
 - (b) Primary participants must attend or designate a proxy at least 24 hours in advance of the meeting.
- (3) Meeting objectives can be accomplished using multiple forums:
 - (a) In-person meetings;
 - (b) Virtual meetings; or
 - (c) Documentation review, without a meeting.
- (4) Voting members have the following options and decisions:
 - (a) Voting Options: Approve, Approve with Conditions, or Disapprove.
 - (b) Decision Options: Identify Action Items and Conditions, Identify Points of Contact (POC), and Identify Due Dates.
- (5) A simple majority (51 percent) of those voting in favor of a motion will pass the motion. The Chair will only vote in the event of a tie vote among voting members.
- (6) Action items and condition tracking:
 - (a) The respective organizations and the Mission Area, agency, or staff office POCs will track action items and conditions.
 - (b) A member of the Governance Team or ITSPG Liaison will notify all stakeholders upon the resolution of the action item.

6. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The following roles and responsibilities are in addition to those outlined in DR 3130-010.

- a. The Deputy Secretary will:
 - (1) Chair the E-Board;
 - (2) Ensure that the E-Board serves as the conduit for decisions; and
 - (3) Provide advice and recommendations through the E-Board to the Secretary.
- b. The CIO will:
 - (1) Serve as the E-Board's Vice Chair; and
 - (2) Serve as the Chair in the absence of the Deputy Secretary.
- c. The ACIO and Deputy ACIO of IRMC will:
 - (1) Serve as the IAB Chair and Vice Chair, respectively; and
 - (2) Reserve the authority to delegate functions and responsibilities as they see fit to carry out IAB functions. Additionally:
 - (a) The IAB Chair (or designated representative) will call IAB meetings;
 - (b) The IAB Chair (or designated representative) will approve agendas;
 - (c) The IAB Chair (or designated representative) will submit recommendations to the CIO and report to the E-Board as required; and
 - (d) The Vice Chair will lead the IAB in any situation when the Chair is not available.
- d. Governance Board General Voting Members will:
 - (1) Represent their organization's interests in proposed decisions, investments, projects, policies, and expenditures;
 - (2) Communicate and support the decisions at their respective Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices by:
 - (a) Attending meetings;
 - (b) Reviewing and assessing all submitted IT investment deliverables on the agenda to make recommendations, approvals, or rejections as appropriate; and

- (c) Reviewing the recommendations provided by supporting boards, considering the larger cross-agency and administrative offices' organizational impact and implications.
- e. Governance Board Non-Voting Members will:
 - (1) Serve as subject matter experts;
 - (2) Provide support, guidance, and expertise during IAB meetings as requested, including:
 - (a) Reviewing IT investment submission in advance, and, if applicable, creating a list of issues, risks, and comments;
 - (b) Validating IT investment information through consultation with Mission Area, agency, or staff office representatives before governance meetings; and
 - (c) Serving as a point of reference for any questions coming from constituent boards.
- f. The IRMC Executive Assistant will:
 - (1) Work together with the ITSPG Liaison and OCIO IRMC ITSPG to ensure that each governance board meeting follows the IITGF;
 - (2) Prepare and distribute minutes of IAB meetings;
 - (3) Provide advice and counsel to the IAB Chair on Governance Team matters;
 - (4) Prepare and distribute the agenda;
 - (5) Announce and coordinate IAB meetings at the IAB Chair's direction;
 - (6) Maintain and safeguard IAB records and ensure their appropriate disposition; and
 - (7) Disseminate, as appropriate, recommendations and decisions reached by the IAB.
- g. The OCIO IRMC ITSPG Enterprise Governance Team Liaison will:
 - (1) Work together with the IRMC Executive Assistant and OCIO IRMC ITSPG to ensure that each governance board meeting is conducted in accordance with the IITGF;
 - (2) Monitor and track follow-on actions to ensure that the governance board's decisions and assignments are implemented properly;

- (3) Provide advice and counsel to the governance board Chairs (E-Board and IAB) on investment matters;
 - (4) Assemble, prepare, and distribute the material on matters under consideration by the governance board in advance of scheduled meetings, conducted per the IITGF;
 - (5) Work together with the ITSPG Liaison and IRMC Executive Assistant to ensure that each governance board meeting follows the IITGF;
 - (6) Solicit agenda items from IAB members and ensure proper representation of items before the IAB;
 - (7) Propose processes to support the functions of the IAB;
 - (8) Provide advice and counsel to the IAB Chair on IAB governance matters;
 - (9) Disseminate specific requirements for data and other actions on behalf of the IAB;
 - (10) Coordinate with the USDA Deputy Secretary's Executive Assistant (or a designee) on the schedule, agenda, and other items pertaining to facilitating E-Board meetings;
 - (11) Prepare advisory reports and recommendations on matters to be brought to the E-Board;
 - (12) Prepare and distribute minutes of E-Board meetings;
 - (13) Announce and coordinate E-Board meetings at the E-Board Chair's direction;
 - (14) Maintain and safeguard E-Board records and ensure their appropriate disposition;
 - (15) Disseminate, as appropriate, the E-Board's recommendations and decisions; and
 - (16) Prepare quarterly IAB status reports for the E-Board.
- h. Mission Area, Agency, and Staff Office IPT Members will:
- (1) Identify business needs and potential IT solutions that align with strategic goals;
 - (2) Coordinate with Investment Managers and PMs to facilitate new projects and investments; and
 - (3) Resolve issues and make sound and timely recommendations to facilitate decision-making.
- i. Mission Area, Agency, and Staff Office IRB Members will:

- (1) Review, discuss, prioritize, and approve IT investments, projects, maintenance, and enhancements regarding the systems in use and any new IT innovation requests; and
- (2) Approve and recommend major investments and projects for enterprise governance review and approval.

j. The Investment Manager or PM will:

- (1) Ensure that funding and resources are in place to support IT investments or projects and that they are used appropriately;
- (2) Develop IITGF and other required deliverables for enterprise governance board meetings; and
- (3) Coordinate with the ITSPG Liaison to ensure that required documentation is completed properly and submitted on time.

7. INQUIRIES

USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices can direct questions and inquiries on this DM to the OCIO IRMC ITSPG at sm.ocio.cio.itgovernance@usda.gov.

-END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

ACIO	Associate Chief Information Officer
CCA	Clinger-Cohen Act
CIO	Chief Information Officer
DM	Departmental Manual
DME	Development, Modernization, and Enhancement
DR	Departmental Regulation
EA	Enterprise Architecture
E-Board	Executive Information Technology Investment Review Board
EITG	Enterprise Information Technology Governance
EVM	Earned Value Management
FITARA	Federal Information Technology Acquisition Reform Act
GAO	Government Accountability Office
IAB	Integrated Advisory Board
IPT	Integrated Project Team
IITGF	Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework
IRB	Investment Review Board
IRMC	Information Resource Management Center
ITPM	Information Technology Portfolio Management
ITSPG	Information Technology Strategic Planning and Governance
IT	Information Technology
ITA	Investment Tailoring Agreement
NLT	No Later Than
OCIO	Office of the Chief Information Officer
O&M	Operations and Maintenance
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
P.L.	Public Law
PM	Project Manager
PMB	Performance Measurement Baseline
POC	Point of Contact
SAOP	Senior Agency Official for Privacy
SPM	Strategic Portfolio Management
U.S.C.	United States Code
USDA	United States Department of Agriculture
WBS	Work Breakdown Structure

APPENDIX B

DEFINITIONS

Control Phase. A phase of the ITPM process. Its purpose is to ensure that, as projects develop and investment expenditures occur, the investment and its associated projects and activities continue to meet mission or business needs at the expected levels of cost and risk. The key objectives are:

- a. To ensure that corrective actions are taken quickly to address any deficiencies in project or operational components; and
- b. To allow an organization to adjust its objectives for an investment and appropriately modify expected outcomes if its mission or business needs change. (Source: CCA)

Earned Value Management (EVM). The technique for measuring project performance and assessing progress during project execution. This system aims to help people identify trends, predict problems, consider solutions, and manage performance more effectively. Essentially, EVM measures project performance against the baselines outlined in a project scope management plan. Using original goals as benchmarks, people can measure progress more accurately and draw actionable conclusions. (Sources: [OMB A-11, FY 2025 Capital Programming Guide](#) and subsequent versions)

Enterprise. An organization that includes interdependent resources (people, organizations, technology) that must be integrated for effective operation.” (Sources: [OMB A-11, FY2025 Capital Programming Guide](#) and subsequent versions)

Enterprise IT Governance (EITG). A set of responsibilities and practices exercised by a board and executive management. EITG provides strategic direction. It ensures that objectives are achieved. It ascertains that risks are managed appropriately. It verifies that the enterprise’s resources are used responsibly. (Source: [DR 3130-010](#))

Evaluate Phase. A phase of the ITPM process. Its purpose is to compare actual versus expected benefits and costs of IT investments and projects. This allows personnel to assess return on investment, customer satisfaction, and value to an organization in meeting its mission and business needs. (Source: CCA)

Governance. A set of processes that ensures the effective and efficient use of IT in enabling an organization to achieve its goals. (Source: [DR 3130-010](#))

Information System. A discrete set of information resources organized for the collection, processing, maintenance, use, sharing, dissemination, or disposition of information. (Source: [44 U.S.C. § 3502\(8\), Definitions](#))

Information Technology (IT). Any equipment or interconnected system or subsystem of equipment used in the automatic acquisition, storage, manipulation, management, movement, control, display, switching, interchange, transmission, or reception of data or information by an executive agency. Related to the terms capital asset, IT investment, program, project, sub-project, service, and system. It also includes computers, ancillary equipment (including imaging peripherals, input, output, and storage devices necessary for security and surveillance), peripheral equipment designed to be controlled by the central processing unit of a computer, software, and firmware. It also includes similar procedures, services (including support services), and related resources. It does not include any equipment acquired by a Federal contractor incidental to a Federal contract (per CCA). However, OMB policy includes this: “supercomputers, software for mission systems, telecommunications, and satellite signal processing.” (Source: *USDA DME and O&M Definitions (and Additional IT-Related Definitions)*)

Information Technology Portfolio Management (ITPM). The combination and management of all IT assets, resources, and investments owned or planned by an organization to achieve its strategic goals, objectives, and mission. (Sources: FY 2022 IT Budget – Capital Planning Guidance and subsequent versions)

Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework (IITGF). An integral part of EITG. Consists of the leadership, structures, and processes that ensure that an organization’s IT sustains and extends its strategies and objectives. Integrated IT governance requires a structure and processes to support repeatable decision-making, alignment of IT activities to the enterprise’s strategic goals and objectives, and a clear understanding of authority and accountability. (Source: *Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework: Guidebook*)

Integrated Project Team (IPT): Are formed to support the planning, execution, and governance of IT investments. At a minimum, IPTs should include representation from business/program leadership, IT, cybersecurity, acquisition, and financial management to ensure cross-functional coordination and accountability across the investment lifecycle. For offices with limited IT staffing, enterprise resources such as EPMO liaisons, ITAs, or OCIO support may be designated to fulfill required roles. IPTs are responsible for developing governance artifacts, preparing for decision gate reviews, and ensuring traceability of scope, schedule, budget, and quality parameters. Mission Areas are encouraged to tailor IPT composition based on project complexity and operational context, while maintaining compliance with IITGF expectations. For assistance in forming an IPT or clarifying role requirements, Mission Areas should contact Enterprise Governance points of contact listed in the guidebook or governance portal.

Investment Manager or Project Manager (PM). The Investment Manager or PM is responsible for ensuring that funding and resources are in place to support an IT investment and that they are used appropriately. These duties can also be performed by a Program Manager or another individual in a similar role who has oversight responsibilities of an investment, project, or system. (Sources: FY 2022 IT Budget – Capital Planning Guidance and subsequent versions)

Investment Tailoring Agreement (ITA). Tailoring is a request to the IAB for customizing or waiving IITGF-specific phases, activities, decision gates, deliverables, or investment governance

reviews. It is based on specific investment requirements or specific business needs. Personnel can complete tailoring requests at any stage of the IITGF process documented in the ITA deliverable. It is the Mission Area, agency, or staff office PM's responsibility to ensure that the major investment meets the required governance needs. (Source: *Integrated Information Technology Governance Framework: Guidebook*)

IT Investment Management. A management process to identify, select, control, and evaluate investments in information systems and resources. The process effectively and efficiently:

- a. Links mission needs, information, and IT;
- b. Integrates with organizational planning, budgeting, procurement, management (financial, human resources, and program), and assessment;
- c. Coordinates with the Department's current and targeted EA; and
- d. Maximizes the value while assessing and managing the risks in the selection, control, and evaluation of information resources.

(Sources: *FY 2022 IT Budget – Capital Planning Guidance* and subsequent versions)

Lifecycle. A set of processes and their temporal relationships that describe a continuous flow of actions and states associated with the existence of a system. The linear sequence of phases of a system's existence that span an initiating action to a closing action, with an implied future re-execution of the sequence. (Source: USDA DME and O&M Definitions (and Additional IT-Related Definitions))

Major IT Investment. An IT investment in Part 1 and Part 2 of the IT portfolio requires special management attention because of its:

- a. Importance to the mission or function of the government;
- b. Significant program or policy implications;
- c. High executive visibility;
- d. High development, operating, or maintenance costs;
- e. Unusual funding mechanism; or
- f. Definition as "major" by the Agency's ITPM process.

OMB may work with the Agency to declare IT investments as major IT investments. Agencies must consult with assigned OMB Desk Officers and Resource Management Offices regarding which investments are considered "major." Investments not considered "major" are "non-

major.” (Sources: *FY 2022 IT Budget – Capital Planning Guidance* and subsequent versions; DR 3130-008)

Major IT Release. A major release introduces wide-ranging changes to the existing software version, including new features to improve the user experience. For example, it might add new features or functionality. (Source: *USDA Definition of Major and Minor Software Releases*)

Mission Area Investment Review Board (IRB): Is an essential governance bodies that ensure IT investments align with USDA strategic priorities, comply with IITGF Gate requirements, and reflect sound business and technical planning. At minimum, IRBs must be chartered with defined decision authority, including representatives from program leadership, IT, acquisition, and finance, and maintain documented procedures for intake, review, and escalation. IRBs should meet regularly to evaluate proposals, validate deliverables, and coordinate with enterprise governance boards when required. Smaller offices may leverage enterprise support to fulfill IRB functions, provided governance responsibilities are clearly assigned and traceable. IRB composition and cadence may vary based on mission needs, but all boards must uphold IITGF standards for transparency, responsiveness, and evidence-based decision-making. Mission Areas seeking guidance on establishing or refining their IRB should reach out to the Enterprise Governance points of contact for tailored support and examples.

Minor IT Release. A minor release introduces small improvements to the software’s functionality. However, changes or modifications are made to existing features instead of the release of new key features. For example, a required patch update. (Source: *USDA Definition of Major and Minor Software Releases*)

Non-Major IT Investment. An IT investment that USDA or OMB does not designate as “major.” A non-major IT investment may be a “standard IT investment,” “IT migration investment,” or “funding transfer investment.” (Sources: *FY 2022 IT Budget – Capital Planning Guidance* and subsequent versions; DR 3130-009)

Project. A temporary endeavor undertaken to create a unique product or service. Projects are different from other ongoing operations in an organization because, unlike operations, projects have a definite beginning and an end. That is, they have a limited duration. (Source: *USDA DME and O&M Definitions (and Additional IT-Related Definitions)*)

Select Phase. A phase of the ITPM process. During this phase, current and potential IT capabilities are evaluated from a business and technical perspective. This is done to validate their efficacy and cost relative to potential alternatives. This evaluation is a critical pillar in conjunction with the agency’s Control and Evaluate phases, which support the continuous evolution and optimization of the agency’s IT portfolio. (Source: [CCA](#))

APPENDIX C

AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

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